

Your Wedding Morning: How to Get Ready.

The morning your photographer is already watching.
How you prepare shapes the first images of your wedding day.

- Your getting ready timeline — how to build it right.
- The space — setting it up for beautiful photos.
- Hair & makeup order — who goes first and why.
- Your gown — the morning-of checklist.
- Details to have ready — rings, florals, flat lays.
- What to expect when we arrive.

NYDAM PHOTOGRAPHY

“Genuine. Intentional. Timeless.”

nydamphoto.com · Austin, Texas · Est. 2008

W E L C O M E

The Morning Already Counts.

The camera is already running when we arrive.
How the morning feels will show in the images.

“The getting ready images are where the story of your wedding day begins.

A calm, prepared morning produces images that feel that way.”

NYDAM PHOTOGRAPHY

Getting ready photography is not a formality at the start of the day. It's where the story begins — the quiet moments with your closest people, the last few minutes before everything changes, the first time you see yourself in your gown with everything on. These images matter as much as any other part of the day.

The brides whose getting ready images are extraordinary have two things in common: their timeline has real buffer built in, and their space was prepared before the photographer arrived. Neither of those things requires extra money or extra effort. They just require reading this guide and acting on it.

This guide covers everything: how to build a timeline that works, how to set up the space, the right order for hair and makeup, what details to have organized and ready, and exactly what to expect when we arrive and the morning begins.

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01

Your Getting Ready Timeline.

The single most common reason getting ready photos suffer is not light, not space — it's a timeline with no buffer. Here is how to build one that works.

BUILDING THE TIMELINE

- + **Start with your ceremony time.**
Work backwards from the moment you need to be ready and in position. Add your travel time, your dress-on time, and your first look or portrait time if applicable. That gives you your hard deadline.
- + **Add a 30-minute buffer. Minimum.**
Something will run long. Hair takes longer than expected. A bridesmaid is late. Someone spills something. A 30-minute buffer is not pessimism — it's the difference between rushing and arriving calm.
- + **Schedule the bride last or second to last.**
You should be in the chair last, or second to last with one bridesmaid after you. You want your hair and makeup as fresh as possible for portraits, and you don't want to be sitting in a robe while everyone else is dressed.
- + **Build in a photographer arrival window.**
we arrive when there is still something to photograph — not after everyone is fully ready and standing around. Typically 60–90 minutes before you need to be dressed. Confirm this with us when we review your timeline together.
- + **Schedule details before hair and makeup.**
Rings, shoes, invitation, florals — photograph best early in the morning when the space is still calm and the light is clean. Not after everyone has been in the room for two hours.
- + **The dress goes on near the end.**
Getting into the gown is one of the most photographed moments of the morning. Schedule it with intention — not rushed, not squashed between two other things. Allow 20–30 minutes for dressing, including lacing, buttoning, and bustle.
- + **First look adds time — and gives it back.**
If you're doing a first look, build in 20–30 minutes before the ceremony. It gives you private couple portraits before the day accelerates and relieves timeline pressure after the ceremony.
- + **Share the timeline with everyone.**
Your hair and makeup artist, your bridesmaids, your coordinator. A timeline only works if everyone has it. Send it the week before. Confirm the morning of.

02

The Space.

Where you get ready shapes every image from that part of the day. A few intentional choices before the photographer arrives make a significant difference to how the morning looks on camera.

Choose the best light in the room.

Identify the window with the most natural light. Position the hair and makeup chair facing or beside it, not with backs to it. This one decision determines the quality of every getting ready portrait.

Clear the background.

Garment bags, suitcases, food containers, random shoes — move them out of frame before the photographer arrives. They take 10 minutes to relocate and they are in every image if you don't.

One room, not the whole suite.

Consolidate getting ready to one clean space. Spreading across multiple rooms splits the light, the energy, and the photographer's ability to capture the story as it unfolds.

Robes or matching getting ready wear.

Not required — but coordinated robes or getting ready outfits make the bridal party images cohesive and intentional. Neutral tones photograph best. Avoid loud patterns near the gown.

Keep the dress visible.

Hang the gown on a wooden or padded hanger on a door frame, curtain rod, or architectural feature with clean space behind it. Not on a bathroom hook. Not on a rolling rack surrounded by other clothes.

Set up a detail surface.

A clean flat surface — a tray, a marble top, a linen-covered table — where rings, shoes, invitation, and jewelry are arranged. This is where detail flat-lay images happen. Have it ready when the photographer arrives.

Temperature and calm.

Texas mornings get warm. Keep the room cool. Hair and makeup under hot tools in a warm room shows on camera by mid-morning. Your comfort is part of how relaxed your images look.

Limit the audience.

The people in the room should be people who belong there. Extra guests, curious family members, people milling around — they create noise, fill the background, and change the energy of the room.

Music: yes. Television: no.

A playlist creates atmosphere and relaxes everyone. A television in the background creates visual and audio noise that competes with what we're trying to create. Turn it off before the photographer arrives.

THE ONE RULE

Clear the background. Face the window. Hang the dress. Set the detail surface.

03

Hair & Makeup Order.

Who sits in the chair and when is not a preference — it's a logistics decision that affects your timeline, your portraits, and how fresh your look is when the camera is on you most.

THE ORDER

+ Bridesmaids first, bride last.

The bride should be in the chair last, or second to last with one bridesmaid scheduled after her. This keeps your look freshest for portraits and ceremony. Getting ready photography of the bride in the chair is most powerful at the end, when anticipation is highest.

+ Bride's hair before bride's makeup.

Hair first, then makeup. Heat and product from styling can affect freshly applied makeup. Doing hair first means makeup goes on a finished, settled canvas.

+ Mother of the bride early.

If your mother is having hair and makeup done, schedule her early — not because she doesn't matter, but because it frees her to be present with you during the final hour, which is where the most emotional mother-daughter images happen.

+ Flower girls: flexible.

Young children are unpredictable. Schedule them with buffer time and don't put them first or last. Middle of the order keeps them ready without waiting too long.

+ Communicate the schedule to your artists.

Your hair and makeup artists need the order at least a week in advance, not the morning of. Include start times, not just order. A written schedule prevents every common morning delay.

+ Build in transition time.

Budget 10–15 minutes between each person — for setup, touch-ups, the artist catching their breath, and unexpected requests. Back-to-back bookings with no gap collapse under real-morning conditions.

+ Touch-ups before the dress.

Schedule a dedicated touch-up pass — powder, lips, hair check — immediately before you get into your gown. Not after. The dressing images are some of the most viewed from the entire day.

+ Photographer arrival vs. your chair time.

we don't need to photograph you in the chair from the start. He arrives to capture the final portion of your makeup, the reveal moment, and the dressing sequence. Confirm the exact arrival window with us when we review your timeline.

04

Your Gown — Morning Checklist.

Getting into your gown is one of the most photographed and most emotional moments of the morning. A few things to have in order before it happens.

BEFORE YOU PUT IT ON

+ Hang it where it can breathe.

The gown should be hanging — not in the garment bag — when you arrive at your getting ready location. On a door frame, a curtain rod, or a clean architectural feature with open space behind it. Not a bathroom hook.

+ Steam if needed — quickly.

If any wrinkles developed in transport, a quick targeted steam on the affected areas. Not a full re-steam. Focus on the train and skirt — the bodice will smooth against the body.

+ Know who is helping you in.

One person handles the dress. Not three. Decide in advance who buttons, who laces, who holds the train. Doing this under camera and with people watching goes smoother when everyone knows their role.

+ Practice the bustle one more time.

The morning of is not the time to figure out the bustle for the first time. If you practiced it before your bridal session, you're ready. If not — do one practice run before we arrive.

+ Shoes and accessories on first.

Put on your shoes and all jewelry before the gown goes on. Reaching over the dress to clasp a necklace or step into heels creates unnecessary risk and unnecessary images of struggle.

+ Clear the floor.

The area where you'll step into the dress should be clear. No bags, no shoes, no cables. You need clean footing and we need a clean floor in the frame.

+ The reveal is a moment.

The first time you see yourself fully dressed is one of the most photographed moments of the morning. Have a full-length mirror in the room. Let the moment happen — don't rush past it.

+ Have your touch-up kit within reach.

Immediately after getting into the gown — before you move, before you hug anyone, before you walk anywhere — do a final face check. Powder, lips, mascara. Then the morning is yours.

05

Details to Have Ready.

Detail images — rings, shoes, florals, invitation — are taken early in the morning when the space is cleanest and the light is freshest. Have everything organized and in one place before the photographer arrives.

Rings together.

Both rings — yours and your partner's — in one place. On a small ring dish, a clean surface, or resting on the invitation. we will photograph them together before they go on.

Your wedding shoes.

Clean, polished, and positioned somewhere with good light. Heel shots, toe shots, shoes with the bouquet — these happen early. Have them out of the box and accessible.

The wedding invitation.

One clean, flat invitation suite — envelope, card, any enclosures — laid on a clean surface. Used as a base for flat lay images. It adds context and is frequently one of the most shared detail images.

Florals: bouquet and any extras.

Your bouquet, any hair florals, boutonniere if present. Have them in water until the last moment. The bouquet appears in detail shots, getting ready portraits, and dressing images — it's in more frames than you expect.

Jewelry laid out.

Earrings, necklace, bracelet — arranged on a clean surface or tray. Not in a jewelry case, not in a pile. Laid intentionally, as if displayed. These images are quiet and beautiful when done with care.

Something borrowed, something meaningful.

An heirloom piece, a note from your partner, your grandmother's handkerchief. Objects with personal history produce the most emotionally resonant detail images. Have it accessible and tell us what it is.

Perfume bottle.

If you have a signature fragrance — especially in a beautiful bottle — include it in the detail arrangement. It adds a personal, intimate quality to the flat lay.

Veil, separated and accessible.

The veil should be easy to access and attach, not buried under other items. It appears in getting ready portraits, dressing images, and detail shots. Know where it is.

A clean tray or surface.

Arrange all detail items on a single surface before the photographer arrives. A marble tray, a linen cloth, a wooden board. The surface itself becomes part of the image.

THE ONE RULE

Have everything on one clean surface before the photographer walks in.

06

When We Arrive.

Here is exactly how the getting ready coverage works — what we focus on, how we move through the morning, and what you never need to manage.

DETAILS FIRST

we go straight to the detail surface when he arrives. Rings, shoes, invitation, florals, jewelry — these are photographed while hair and makeup is still in progress. You don't need to stop. You don't need to pose. The morning continues while the details are captured.

THE CANDID PHASE

While the final bridesmaids are finishing and you're in the chair, we move through the room quietly — the energy between you and your closest people, the small moments that happen when no one is performing for a camera. This is photojournalistic work. You don't direct it. Neither do we.

THE DRESS SEQUENCE

When it's time to put on the gown, we position to capture the full sequence: the dress being lifted, the lacing or buttoning, the adjustment of the train, the first look in the mirror. This is directed — he will ask for the space to work and guide the moment so the images are intentional, not chaotic.

THE REVEAL

The first time you see yourself fully dressed, with veil, shoes, and jewelry on, is one of the most emotionally charged moments of the morning. we will be in position for it. Your only job is to let yourself feel it. Don't rush to the mirror. Don't check your phone. Just be in it.

BRIDAL PORTRAITS IN THE SPACE

After dressing, there is usually time for a short portrait sequence in the getting ready space or just outside it — solo bridal portraits and bridal party images before you move to the ceremony. These happen in the final 20–30 minutes. Build this time into your timeline.

WHAT YOU NEVER NEED TO MANAGE

You will never need to gather people for us, point out what to photograph, or direct any part of the morning. Brief us once on anything specifically important to you. After that — he moves. You just live the morning.

“The camera is always running. Your only job is to be present.”

About Nydam Photography.

We have been photographing Austin families, seniors, couples, and milestones since 2008. Every session we do is personal. We arrive prepared — every session planned with intention — and we create something real.

We photograph with natural light and flash — almost always, even outdoors — because the quality of the image matters more than the convenience of the approach. Every image is considered. Every detail is intentional.

GENUINE

Every portrait should feel like you — not a polished version of someone else. We create the conditions for real moments, then capture them.

INTENTIONAL

Light, posing, expression, timing — every element of a great portrait is considered in advance and guided with care throughout.

TIMELESS

We edit for longevity, not for trends. The images we create together are meant to stop you in your tracks ten years from now.

Weddings · Families & Portraits · Seniors · Sacraments · Quinceañeras · Events · Sports · Corporate Headshots & Branding

Every specialty. One standard of care.

KNOW SOMEONE WHO DESERVES THIS?

Pass this guide along — or send them directly to us. The right photographer changes everything. If you found yours — share that gift. A referral from a client is the highest compliment we receive.

With warmth,

Arlen and Tanya Nydam, Nydam Photography

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